Consensus Change Standards

Executive Brief — a summary for policymakers, operators, and busy readers

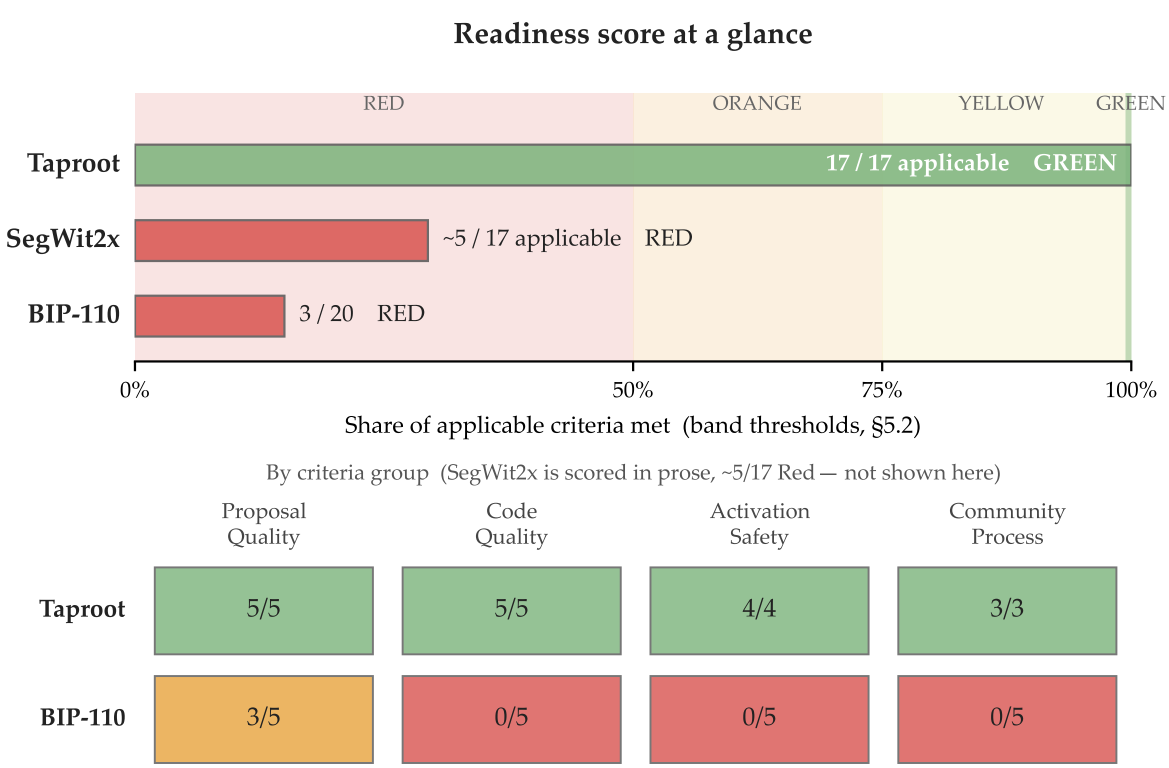
A Legal and Technical Framework for Bitcoin Protocol Governance · Fourth Edition, 2026 · The Forum Press

The catastrophic failure mode of a Bitcoin consensus change — a permanent chain split — has a **computable** probability. At **55%** hashrate enforcement the chance of a six-block reorganization during activation is roughly **thirty percent**; by **90%** or above it is **effectively zero**, five to seven orders of magnitude lower. Much of the governance argument is a fight over that one number.

What this is

A neutral, public **20-criterion readiness checklist** for judging whether a proposed change to Bitcoin's shared consensus rules has been adequately reviewed before it goes live. The criteria fall in four groups — **Proposal Quality, Code Quality, Activation Safety, Community Process** — and a proposal is scored Green / Yellow / Orange / Red on the share it meets. It is **not** a proposed law and **not** a change to Bitcoin's code; it sets standards for the *process* by which changes are evaluated, debated, and adopted or rejected. It is procedurally neutral — the same standards apply whether a change would liberalize Bitcoin's policy or restrict it.

What it found



Applied to real proposals: **Taproot scores 17/17 (Green)**; **BIP-110 scores 3/20 (Red)**; and **SegWit2x scores roughly 5/17 (Red)**. To show the framework measures *process, not preference*, it also scores a hypothetical change the author's own mining revenue would favor — and that change scores Red too.

Why a policymaker should care

A rushed change that ignores documented red flags is not just a technical risk — it is a **legal** one. The framework's force is **deterrence, not enforcement**: a documented Red score is a dated, public record that supplies the *notice* and *foreseeability* the negligence and negligent-misrepresentation theories of the full paper's legal analysis depend on, should a change be activated anyway and cause loss. The flip side is the protection: **following the standard is itself the defense.** Compliance is the defense; the score is the exposure.

Is it a cartel?

No. The framework **binds no one and asks for no agreement**: it publishes criteria each operator applies *unilaterally* to the listing, custody, and risk decisions it already makes. Independent parallel conduct on published criteria is not a Sherman Act violation; only an actual *agreement* to refuse would raise the antitrust concern — the posture the framework is designed never to form, and the model adoption language is drafted accordingly.

Read the full 96-page paper. `github.com/asaffulks/consensus-change-standards` · DOI `10.5281/zenodo.20651832`

· *Cite as:* Asaf Fulks, *Consensus Change Standards: A Legal and Technical Framework for Bitcoin Protocol Governance* (4th ed. 2026). This brief summarizes; the paper, its authorities, and its caveats govern.